

NEPAL FLASH FLOODS: 21 escaped by scrambling up a slippery ridge, aided by cables and a saree

Everything changed in 2 seconds: Survivors

E T B SIVAPRIYAN
CHENNAI, DHNS

46-year-old M Sivaranjani began recording a video on her smartphone when she witnessed huge plumes of smoke emanating from her minibus, not realising they were caught in the massive flash floods in Nepal's Rasuwa district. Only when she noticed a massive wave of boulders and debris rolling with the water — accompanied by a deafening, blast-like sound — did the Tiruchirappalli resident realise all was not well.

Within seconds, the vehicle stalled, and the local driver fled, leaving all 21 occupants in danger. They were on their way to the Kailash Mansarovar yatra and were just a few kms before crossing over into Tibet.

“Everything was absolutely fine just two seconds before the flash floods. Everything changed two seconds later. When we turned back, we could only see vehicles and people being washed away in the flash floods. We kept screaming,” Sivaranjani told *DH*, recounting their harrowing experience in Nepal.

“It was Lord Shiva who saved us,” she said, taking long pauses while narrating their miraculous escape from nature's fury and how they climbed a ridge to seek refuge in an Armed Police Force (APF) camp of the Nepal Police.

58-year-old Sathiya Jayaraman, a government school headmaster in Kundrathur on the outskirts of Chennai, said they scrambled to safety by jumping out of the bus one by one using the right-side door, through which the driver had escaped.

“What unfolded before us was straight from an English movie. We jumped into the sludge. It was slippery, and the rains were heavy, but we somehow walked and reached a spot from where we could climb a ridge,” Sathiya said.

“We couldn't climb the ridge easily since it was slippery — if we climbed four feet, we

slipped back five. Men in our group climbed the ridge first using cables and sent those cables back to us,” the headmaster said.

A woman, Poonkulazhi, climbed the ridge and threw down her saree for elderly passengers to use as a lifeline to reach safety. “It was the saree that helped us escape to safety. She removed her saree and wore a sweater,” she said, her voice choking.

Bhuvaneswari, who was travelling with her husband and relatives, said she would not have reached the ridge without the saree, as she fell down thrice due to the slippery terrain.

“We just wanted to stay alive. I clung to a tree for a long time. The men in the group helped all of us to climb the ridge. Fortunately, the saree was strong enough, and we also took the help of the cables. It took about 1.5 hours for all of us to climb the ridge,” she told *DH*.

Sivaranjani, Bhuvaneswari, and Sathiya are part of the 21-member group that reached Chennai after being rescued from Nepal — these are part of a 57-member tourist group that went to Kailash Mansarovar through a Kumbakonam-based tourist agency.

The survivors are clueless about the fate of the 36 others who travelled with them from Chennai and were in two mini-buses, which are feared to have been washed away in the flash floods.

Bhuvaneswari said she saw a car turn upside down due to the impact of the flash floods, with several other vehicles submerged under water.

“I think we were the luckiest. From the ridge, we saw the disaster unfold before us,” she said.

The entourage climbed another ridge on Thursday morning — an arduous trek for those above the age of 50, who required assistance from others — to reach a makeshift helipad. “We were transported back to Kathmandu by chopper in batches,” Sivaranjani said.



An Indian Air Force C-130 aircraft departed with 10 tonnes of essential relief supplies, including medicines and food items, to support those affected in Nepal flash flood. PTI



Priests perform Ganga 'Aarti' as people offer prayers for the flash flood victims at Ramghat, in Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh. PTI



A tourist being received by family members and relatives after arriving at Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport in Mumbai on Saturday. PTI

Tea break saved lives of 5 Ch'garh friends

But for a tea break, five friends from Chhattisgarh could have been swept away in the flash floods that devastated Bhote Koshi and Trishuli river valleys in Nepal on Wednesday.

They survived, but then had to spend two anxious days watching the fury of the swollen Trishuli river from an elevated spot.

Narayan Sen, Dinesh Ojha, Prem Singh Jagat, Yatendra Prakash and Dinesh Singh Thakur, all aged between 50 and 60 years and residents of Mana Camp area in Raipur, returned home on Saturday.

287 Indians missing, 88 rescued: MEA

NEW DELHI, PTI: At least 287 Indians remained missing while 88 others were rescued following the devastating flash floods along the Nepal-Tibet border four days back, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Saturday.

It said 128 persons of Indian origin have also been uncontactable. The MEA also said that 120 Indian nationals stranded on the Chinese side have safely crossed over to Nepal on Saturday.

Four Indian nationals — Ripu Kumar, Chaneshwar Narzary, Kripa Shankar

and Mohammed Minhajuddin — were rescued from a hydropower project in Rasuwa, it said, adding they are expected to reach Kathmandu soon.

Rasuwa was among the areas severely impacted by the floods.

The MEA said India sent a six-member team of forensic experts to Nepal on Saturday to help local authorities to analyse DNA samples for identification of mortal remains of those killed in the floods.

India has also sent a specialised technical team for tunnel reconnaissance and rescue to the neighbouring

country as part of its support.

“The team started working from today to assist in tunnel rescue in the impacted area. Based on their recommendation, a specialised tunnel rescue team from India with equipment is expected to reach Nepal today,” the MEA said on social media.

It said 88 Indian nationals were rescued and 287 remained missing as of Saturday.

Since Wednesday night, India sent a total of 57.5 tonnes of emergency supplies to Nepal in three military transport aircraft.

Punjab influencer dies weeks after being set on fire

CHANDIGARH, PTI: Punjabi social media influencer Manjit Kaur has died at a government hospital here, almost two months after she was allegedly assaulted and set on fire.



Manjit Kaur

Manjit, 28, died during treatment at the Postgraduate Institute of Medical Education and Research (PGIMER) on August 26, police said on Saturday.

According to her mother's complaint, Manjit was allegedly kidnapped by her two acquaintances on July 3. She was allegedly taken to Morinda in Punjab, where she was assaulted, tied to a tree and set on fire, the complaint stated.

Manjit's friend reached the spot and rushed her to a hospital in Morinda. She was later taken to a Mohali hospital and then to PGIMER.

BJP pulls up 3 MPs for Sajjan Kumar condolences

Reiterates its position on justice for 1984 anti-Sikh riots victims

NEW DELHI, DHNS

BJP national president Nitin Nabin has pulled up three party MPs from Delhi for visiting the family of former Congress leader and 1984 anti-Sikh riots convict Sajjan Kumar to offer condolences, sources said.

The MPs are Kamaljeet Sehrawat, Ramvir Singh Bidhuri and Yogender Chandolia. However, the party did not officially disclose the names.

The party's reaction comes amid a political controversy triggered by the visit, which drew sharp criticism from senior advocate and anti-1984 riots campaigner HS Phoolka.



Nitin Nabin



Ramvir Singh Bidhuri



Kamaljeet Sehrawat



Yogender Chandolia

Phoolka questioned the propriety of the BJP leaders paying a condolence visit to the family of a man convicted in cases linked to the anti-Sikh riots.

“Grateful to Nitin Nabin for taking a strong stance on the issue,” Phoolka said in a post on X.

Following the backlash, BJP sought to distance itself from the episode, saying the MPs' visit was in their personal capacity and that their presence at the residence of Sajjan Kumar's family did not constitute the party's official position.

Party sources said Nabin sought an explanation from the MPs and conveyed the leadership's displeasure over the visit.

“The visit was a personal decision of the individuals concerned and should not be construed as the BJP's stand,” a party functionary said, adding that the party's position on the 1984 anti-Sikh riots and securing justice for the victims remains unchanged.

The controversy assumes significance due to the BJP's longstanding criticism of the Congress over the anti-Sikh riots and its efforts to project itself as a party committed to ensuring justice for the riot victims.

Party leaders said the BJP leadership viewed the matter seriously and had communicated its concerns to those involved.

J&K HC seeks fresh report on religious encroachments

ZULFIKAR MAJID
SRINAGAR, DHNS

The Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh High Court has sought a fresh account of religious structures allegedly encroaching on public streets, parks and other public places in Kashmir, asking the administration to spell out the action taken against existing encroachments and measures to prevent fresh ones.

A Division Bench comprising Acting Chief Justice Sanjeev Kumar and Justice Mohammad Yousuf Wani directed the Divisional Commissioner, Kashmir, to file a fresh affidavit identifying such encroachments, if any.

The direction came after the court examined a status report submitted by the Divisional Commissioner in an ongoing public interest litigation concerning encroachment of public land for religious structures.

The report listed religious structures on state, ‘Kah-

PUBLIC SPACE

- The direction came after the Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh High Court examined a status report that listed religious structures on public land
- The report did not indicate whether the structures had encroached upon public streets, parks or other spaces
- Administration has six weeks to submit action-taken report
- The matter is listed for October 12

charai’ and ‘Shamilat Deh’ land, but did not specifically indicate whether any of them had encroached upon public streets, public parks or other public places.

The court also sought details of the steps taken to deal with existing encroachments and prevent similar constructions in the future.

The fresh affidavit is to cover mosques, temples, churches and gurdwaras. The administration has been given six weeks to submit the

report, with the matter listed for October 12.

The proceedings are significant in the context of a 2009 Supreme Court directive that no unauthorised religious construction be permitted on public streets, public parks and other public places.

The apex court had also directed authorities to review existing structures on a case-by-case basis. In 2018, it directed the respective High Courts to monitor implementation of those directions.

The J&K High Court has been examining the issue separately as part of its ongoing proceedings. Its latest direction seeks a more specific account of whether public spaces have been encroached upon by religious structures and what action, if any, has followed.

The court also took note of a compliance report from Ladakh, which indicated that there were no encroachments by religious institutions on public streets, public parks or other public places.

T'gana CM urges CEC to extend deadline for SIR objections

HYDERABAD, DHNS: Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy has written to Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar requesting a few weeks' extension of the September 16 deadline for claims and objections under the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

He stressed that the SIR must not remove any eligible voter's name, nor enrol any ineligible voter. In his Saturday letter, he also asked that procedural safeguards be introduced to give voters adequate time and support.

Citing EC data, the CM noted that as of June 10, Telangana had 3.38 crore voters, of whom 73.39 lakh (21.7%) had been flagged as Absent, Shifted, Dead, or Duplicate (ASDD).

Of particular concern, he said, was that nearly 62% of this category — 45.19 lakh voters — had been classified as permanently relocated.



Mattresses and debris is seen coming out of windows of a damaged house in the aftermath of flash floods at Devighat in Nepal's Nuwakot district on Saturday. AFP

GST body meet on Sept 12 may discuss simplified registration

NEW DELHI, DHNS: The 57th GST Council meeting is set to be held on September 12 in the Capital, over a year after approving rate rationalisation and other reforms that led to significant reduction in taxes.

As per an “office memorandum” issued by Revenue Secretary Arvind Srivastava, there will be an officers' meeting on September 11. The venue and agenda will be announced later.

At the 56th meeting held on September 3, 2025, the Council approved significant reduction in GST rates across segments, including automobiles, electronics, medicine, agricultural equipment and food items. It was the biggest

overhaul in indirect tax rates since the introduction of the goods and services tax (GST) regime in July 2017.

According to analysts, the Council is likely to discuss simplification of the GST registration for large businesses and automation of registration cancellation procedures.

“Key areas awaiting deliberation include legal and technology amendments and enhancements to safeguard bona fide recipients of Input Tax Credit when suppliers default — an issue underscored in the Maruti Enterprises ruling and affirmed by the Supreme Court in Bhandari Scrap Traders,” said Vivek Jalan, Partner, Tax Connect Advisory Services.

PATNA, PTI

Bihar to replace ‘fail’ with ‘eligible for skill training’ on Board marksheets

The Bihar government has decided to replace the word “fail” with the phrase “eligible for skill training” in the marksheets of students appearing for Class 10 and Class 12 board examinations from the current academic session, officials said on Saturday.

The move is aimed at enabling the students to pursue vocational training programmes offered by the Bihar Board of Open Schooling and Examination (BBOSE), they said.

“The Education Department will amend the rules accordingly to implement this change. The department will soon issue necessary instructions to the BSEB. Instead of ‘Fail’, the certificates will carry the term ‘Eligible for Skill Development,’” Bihar Education Minister Mithlesh Tiwari told

reporters here.

Tiwari said students' talent does not disappear merely because they fail to secure the expected marks in an examination.

“Students appearing for the Class 10 board supplementary examinations will be provided special sessions for one month to help them prepare and improve their chances of success,” he said.

The initiative is part of broader efforts to provide remedial support and prevent students from falling behind after an unsuccessful examination attempt, the education minister said.

The Bihar government has been taking measures to provide students with greater exposure to activities beyond conventional textbook-based learning, the officials said. One of the latest moves is the introduction of ‘no-bag day’ on Saturdays in government schools.

BJP rejects Cong's charge over ‘purification’ ritual at Kharge rally venue

NEW DELHI, PTI: The BJP on Saturday rejected the Congress's allegation that a “purification” ceremony was held at the venue of a rally addressed by its president, Mallikarjun Kharge, in Uttarakhand's Haldwani because of his caste, while accusing Rahul Gandhi of “peddling falsehood” to divide the society merely to serve his political agenda.

At the BJP headquarters, party spokespersons Sudhanshu Trivedi and Guru Prakash Paswan played videos of two members of the Shri Ram Sena Dharmarth Seva Nyas Sangathan, who asserted that a “puja” and a “havan” performed at the venue after Kharge's event held

earlier this month were part of a “cleanliness exercise”, because the stage was left dirty and there was a temple nearby.

“I also belong to the Scheduled Castes. I was present there. The puja and the havan performed there were part of a cleanliness exercise. There was dirt on the stage. Ramlila is performed there. There is also a temple nearby,” Ankit Pal of the sangathan was heard telling reporters in one of the video clips.

Vinod Arya, another member of the outfit, also made similar claims, saying he is a Dalit and the site was cleaned not because of any caste bias against any individual.

Latching on to the clarification

from Pal and Arya, Trivedi said, “It is clear from these two videos that there was no caste angle involved.”

“Rahul Gandhi keeps raising one issue after another, ranging from patriarchy, gender bias, region, language to caste discrimination, but the fact is that he has just one goal — how to pitch Hindus against each other and carry forward the agenda of (Lord) Macaulay, (Karl) Marx and maulanas,” he said.

BJP general secretary (organisation) B L Santhosh slammed Gandhi for his remarks, saying the leader of the opposition in the Lok Sabha might get some likes on social media but not public endorsement for his claims.